that assembly or be elected to office. It was also difficult for Naxos, Thasos and other subject lands to coordinate a united opposition to the decisions taken in the Athenian centre, and if they tried to do so, it would have brought ruthless Athenian reprisals. Information in the Athenian Empire flowed to and from Athens.[23]

When the Roman Republic built its empire, conquering first the Italian peninsula and eventually the entire Mediterranean basin, the Romans took a somewhat different course. Rome gradually did extend citizenship to the conquered people. It began by granting citizenship to the inhabitants of Latium, then to the inhabitants of other Italian regions, and finally to inhabitants of even distant provinces like Gallia and Syria. However, as citizenship was extended to more people, the political rights of citizens were simultaneously restricted.

The ancient Romans had a clear understanding of what democracy means, and they were originally fiercely committed to the democratic ideal. After expelling the last king of Rome in 509 BCE, the Romans developed a deep dislike for monarchy and a fear of giving unlimited power to any single individual or institution. Supreme executive power was therefore shared by *two* consuls who balanced each other. These consuls were chosen by citizens in free elections, held office for a single year and were additionally checked by the powers of the popular assembly, of the Senate and of other elected officials like the tribunes.

But when Rome extended citizenship to Latins, Italians and finally to Gauls and Syrians, the power of the popular assembly, the tribunes, the Senate and even the two consuls was gradually reduced, until in the late first century BCE the Caesar family established its autocratic rule. Anticipating present-day strongmen like Putin, Augustus didn't crown himself king, and pretended that Rome was still a republic. The Senate and the popular assembly continued to convene, and every year citizens continued to choose consuls and tribunes. But these institutions were emptied of real power.[24]

In 212 CE, the emperor Caracalla – the offspring of a Phoenician family from North Africa – took a seemingly momentous step and granted automatic Roman citizenship to all free adult males throughout the vast empire. Rome in the third century CE accordingly had tens of millions of citizens.[25] But by that time, all the important decisions were made by a single unelected emperor. While consuls were still ceremonially chosen